Postmodernism in Anthropology

Anthropological theories: (j) Post-modernism in anthropology — the reflexive, literary turn of the 1980s

4 PYQs 2012 · 2015 · 2024 · 2025
72 marks · 20-markers in 2024 and 2025 · none in 2026 · rising: features → philosopher → application · Mains Value **High**

THE ANSWER SPINE ① No metanarrative → ② Ethnography is writing → ③ Power/knowledge → ④ Reflexivity, voice, open culture → ⑤ Gains and costs

① WHAT IT IS — AND THE PHILOSOPHERS

2012 · note philosophers now named

Lyotard, *The Postmodern Condition* (1979): "incredulity toward metanarratives" — progress, reason, science, Marxism.

Definition: rejects universal truths and grand theories; knowledge and identity are **constructed, plural, bound up with power**; attends to language, representation and the knower's position.

Postmodernity = the condition (Jameson: cultural logic of late capitalism, 1991) · **postmodernism** = the theory · **post-structuralism** = its French core.

Thinker	Carry into anthropology
Derrida 1966–67	deconstruction; différance
Foucault 1969–76	power/knowledge; discourse makes its objects
Said 1978	representation as domination
Baudrillard 1981	simulacra, hyperreality

② WHY THE TURN — AND THE 1986 CANON

2020 · 15M adjacent

Pressures: Asad, *Colonial Encounter* 1973 · Malinowski's **diary** 1967 · Said 1978 · Fabian, *Time and the Other* 1983 — **denial of coevalness** · Geertz's textual turn · feminism · experimental texts: Rabinow 1977, Crapanzano *Tuhami* 1980, Dwyer 1982, Shostak *Nisa* 1981.

> **Santa Fe seminar 1984 → Clifford & Marcus, *Writing Culture* (1986).** Clifford, "Partial Truths": ethnographic truths are "**inherently partial — committed and incomplete**".

- **Clifford 1983** — four modes of authority: experiential · interpretive · **dialogic** · **polyphonic**.
- **Marcus & Fischer 1986** — "crisis of representation"; experimental moment; **cultural critique**.
- **Tyler 1986** — ethnography should **evoke**, not represent (← 6-I).
- **Geertz 1988** *Works and Lives* · **Rosaldo 1989** positioned subject · **Abu-Lughod 1991** "Writing against Culture" · **Gupta & Ferguson 1992** · **Marcus 1995** multi-sited (2025 note) · **Appadurai 1996** scapes.

Counter-case — feminists left out. Clifford excused their absence; Mascia-Lees, Sharpe & Cohen (1989) replied that feminism questioned objectivity first and kept a politics; Behar & Gordon, *Women Writing Culture* (1995).

★ HERO — THE CRISIS OF REPRESENTATION

draw for 2012 · 2015 · 2025

REALIST · to c. 1970	BASIS	POSTMODERN · 1980s on
"I was there" — objective	**authority**	questioned — **reflexivity**
one — the author's	**voice**	many — **polyphony**, dialogue
bounded, integrated whole	**culture**	contested, hybrid, open
the "ethnographic present"	**time**	history and coevalness
a master paradigm	**theory**	no metanarrative
a transparent window	**the text**	rhetoric — **partial truths**
a science of society	**aim**	evocation; cultural critique
Argonauts 1922; The Nuer 1940	**exemplar**	Writing Culture 1986

③ THE BASIC FEATURES — THE 2015 QUESTION

2015 · 20M
2012 · 12M

Line: less a new theory of culture than a **new theory of ethnography** — who has the authority to describe a culture, and how. **Attach an anthropologist to every feature.**

1 Crisis of representation — Marcus & Fischer 1986

2 No master paradigm — Lyotard; evolutionism to structuralism dethroned

3 Ethnography as text — Clifford 1986; Geertz 1988

4 Reflexivity — Rabinow 1977; Rosaldo 1989

5 Polyphony, dialogue — Clifford 1983; Crapanzano; Dwyer

6 Culture contested, open — Abu-Lughod 1991; Gupta & Ferguson

7 Power/knowledge, colonial critique — Foucault; Asad; Said; Fabian

8 Relativism of standpoint — Tyler (strong), Clifford (moderate)

9 Experimental writing — Shostak; Tyler's evocation

10 Multi-sited, global — Marcus 1995; Appadurai 1996

Counter-case — the critics: Spiro 1996 (anti-science, relativism) · Harris 1999 (obscurantism, idealism) · Sangren 1988 (navel-gazing) · Gellner 1992 · D'Andrade 1995 (moral vs objective models).

④ DERRIDA AND DECONSTRUCTION

2024 · 20M "critically"

Derrida (1930–2004) — "Structure, Sign and Play" (1966) · *Of Grammatology*, *Writing and Difference* (1967). A **practice of reading**, not destruction.

A / B	A > B	B ⊂ A	A ⇄ B
identify the binary	expose the hierarchy	reverse it	displace it

Logocentrism (a fixed centre of meaning) · **phonocentrism** (speech over writing) · ***différance*** = differ + defer · trace · supplement · "**nothing outside the text**" = nothing reaches us outside signs — *not* "the world is unreal".

Counter-case — Derrida on Lévi-Strauss: structure needs a centre outside its own play; the engineer/bricoleur contrast collapses. "The Violence of the Letter": the Nambikwara writing lesson romanticises an innocent oral society — **ethnocentrism in reverse**.

Uses: ethnography read as text · binaries — civilised/primitive, home/field, self/Other · "tribe", "caste" as colonial categories (Cohn 1996; Dirks 2001).
Critique: textualism, relativism (Habermas), quietism — but "Force of Law" 1990.

⑤ JUSTICE AND THE MARGINALISED

2025 · 20M "how relevant"

GIVES	COSTS	RESOLUTION
deconstructs development (Escobar 1995; Ferguson 1990) · whose knowledge counts (Foucault; FRA 2006) · categories unmade (criminal tribes 1871 → 1952; PTG → PVTG) · voice (Subaltern Studies) · situated knowledge (Gopal Guru 2002)	relativism undercuts rights · fragmentation vs solidarity · text over land and wages (Harris) · elitist prose (Nussbaum 1999) · intellectuals speak over the subaltern (Spivak 1988)	strategic essentialism (Spivak) · militant, ethical anthropology (Scheper-Hughes 1995) · voice made law: PESA 1996, FRA 2006

> **Niyamgiri (2013):** the Supreme Court let the Dongria Kondh gram sabhas decide on their religious and cultural rights; all twelve consulted rejected bauxite mining — a local sacred voice against a development metanarrative.

India set: Subaltern Studies · Cohn, Dirks, Inden · "tribe as colonial construct" (P-II 2016) · Raheja & Gold 1994 · Veena Das 1995 · Srinivas, *The Remembered Village* 1976 (reflexive precursor).

Traps: Geertz is a precursor, not a postmodernist · deconstruction ≠ destruction · "critically" stems need the limits.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE Postmodernism changed less what anthropology says culture is than **how it claims to know and write it**: no metanarrative, partial truths, power in every category, voice for the studied. Its costs — relativism, navel-gazing, a drift from material inequality — are real. As a programme for writing it faded; as a **sensibility** — reflexive, ethical, multi-sited, alert to power — it won, and it empowers the marginalised when its suspicion of power is joined to a defence of rights.